

Paper 10: Deleuze, Guattari, Erotic Misery

This paper, while primarily focusing on the last chapter of Toscano's *Late Fascism*, "Cathedrals of Erotic Misery" will also incorporate some insights from Felix Guattari's essay, "Everybody Wants to be a Fascist", which I find relevant. In general, all three of the titular thinkers, Deleuze, Guattari, and Toscano are interested in subverting the generalization that fascism was primarily enacted through a centralized and explicitly governmental system. It continues to build on lessons like Fromm's "Sociopsychological Dimensions", the assertion that true authority must contain an element of self-identification and cannot rely completely on coercion.

Toscano begins the chapter with Foucault, citing his words at the 1975 Schizo-Culture conference in New York City. On the topic of fascism, Freud spoke of its new forms, new modes of consciousness, as well as new ways of resisting it. Similarly, Guattari mentions in his piece that a proper examination of the fascist ethos starts by recognizing the political moment and comparing it some historical benchmark. He describes the methodology as having to "progress constantly in the direction of a molecularization of its object to be able to grasp, from up close, the role that it plays in the heart of the large groupings within which it functions" (Guattari, 162). What this means is that one must characterize movements like National Socialism with a dual precision. On the one hand, it would be a mischaracterization to say there was a singular Nazi party because throughout its reign, the functions the party took on changed as the conditions

which it was operating within changed. On the other hand, Guattari pushes a “refusal of those simplifications which prevent us from perceiving the *genealogy* and the *permanence* of certain fascist machineries.”

We can observe this need for precision in the ways people tend to group totalitarian movements, but Guattari as suggests, the differences between various epochs of fascism are probably greater than the popular comparison between Stalinism and Nazism. It really comes down to the smallest details, the things that people tend to miss which explain the genetic code of these ideologies. In an earlier class, Professor Vogt mentioned that even the ways authoritarians engage in crowd work is a signal to the relationship developed between leaders and the masses. Stalin, when applauded by his supporters, would join in the applause as a demonstration of affinity. Neither Hitler nor Mussolini did the same, but what otherwise comes off as minutia is a remarkable indicator of desire, a term that is of utmost importance to all three aforementioned thinkers. Continuing the comparison, Stalinism, despite its appearance centering on collectivity, was arguably more machine-coded and mechanized than fascism. It is what gave the regime the advantage of stability but also the rigidity that eventually led to its downfall. In its wake, but also long before the power vacuum took place, “fascism had already made it.” It is this point that equally fascinates Toscano.

Speaking of which, Toscano takes Guattari’s above quote and builds upon it. Fascism was unique in that it addressed people’s deepest fears and fixations very dishonestly. It hit all the notes on sexuality, repression, sadomasochistic tendencies, and almost every other imaginable psychosocial stress factor. A particular passage stuck out to me, originating from Guattari and shared by Toscano in conversation with Foucault: “We never desire against our interests, because interests always follows and finds itself where desire has placed it. We cannot shut out the

scream of Wilhelm Reich: the masses were not deceived; at a particular time, they actually wanted a fascist regime!” (pg. 139). As the dialogue continues, Foucault emphasized the “erotic” manner in which power was distributed. The way Toscano sees it, “Fascism is not just the apotheosis of the leader above the sheeplike masses of his followers; it is also... the reinvention of the settler logic of petty sovereignty, a highly conditional but very real ‘liberalizing’ and ‘privatizing’ of the monopoly of violence.

By this point, we’re all familiar with this story – the line dividing life and death; order and chaos; celibacy and sex; and more recently thanks to the work of scholars on the gendering of fascist libido, patriarchy and heterogeneity were thinner than anyone could possibly imagine. It was National Socialism that showed the world what happened when one particular society rode these lines to their extreme. Meanwhile, its afterimages, the various post-fascisms of the world continue to blur them. At this point, I was surprised this question hasn’t been asked in class already, but it leads me to pose this thought experiment and encouraged to engage in a moment of critical honesty: What elements of fascism do you find most desirable? As Foucault might say, where is the fascist that lies within each of us?